LAF YOMI

Bekhorot 40 · October 28, 2026

ON TODAY'S DAF

Bekhorot 40: the tail-blemish sugya spins off into the Temple's two measuring cubits in Shushan HaBira, the hidden-testicle squeeze test and Akiva's clash with Yochanan ben Nuri, extra and missing legs, a human-like eye, a pig-like mouth, goat-versus-lamb tail vertebrae, and the wart in the eye — black or white, hairy or bare.

שושן הבירה · THE TEMPLE'S PERSIAN SKYLINE



1. The Temple's attic storeroom was called Shushan HaBira because it carried a picture of the Persian capital's skyline.

“The Persians made them hang it there so they'd always remember who was really in control. The Beit HaMikdash had imperial branding on the wall.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40a · שושן הבירה — the Temple attic with the Persian skyline · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 13:55

אחת גדולה ואחת קטנה · THE TEMPLE'S RIGGED RULERS



2. The Temple's two cubits were both deliberately oversized: the northeast one half a finger over Moshe's cubit, the southeast one a full finger over.

“Workers took with the small cubit and returned with the large one, so the Temple always came out ahead — the only honest use of dishonest measures.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40a · למה אחת גדולה ואחת קטנה — take with the small, return with the large · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 17:50

עד מתי · AKIVA AND YOCHANAN BEN NURI TRADE INSULTS



3. After the squeeze test in Beis Menachem failed to produce the hidden testicle, Akiva ruled the animal a baal mum and Yochanan ben Nuri ruled it kosher — and they went at each other.

“Akiva: 'How long will you consume Israel's money?' Yochanan ben Nuri: 'How long will you feed Israel neveilot?' And the Teshuvah Me'ahavah's ledger: wrongly declaring kosher meat treif steals a fellow's money — bein adam lachaveiro — while wrongly permitting is only bein adam laMakom. So better to err lenient.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40a · עד מתי אתה מכלה ממונם של ישראל — Akiva vs. Yochanan ben Nuri · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 27:53

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כל יתר כנטול דמי · SPREAD TOO THIN IS A TREIFAH



4. An animal with an extra hind leg is a treifah — extra counts as missing, since maybe one of the legs it needs is the defective one.

“A person who is all over the place, not concentrating properly, spread too thin — he himself is a treifah. And the Sefat Emet: Avraham was only called tamim once milah removed his 'extra' — Yaakov said 'yesh li rav,' Esav said 'yesh li kol.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40a · כל יתר כנטול דמי — the extra leg that makes a treifah · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 35:02

מתניתין אטעיתיה · THE MISHNAH THAT MISLED RAV HUNA



5. Rav Huna ruled: a goat with two tail vertebrae is a mum, three is fine; a lamb with three is a mum, four is fine.

“A baraita says the opposite — a goat with one vertebra is a mum, two is fine. The Gemara: the Mishnah misled him. The first half was about a goat's ear, so he assumed the tail part was too — but the seifa is about a lamb. Even Rav Huna got tripped by a mid-Mishnah animal switch.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40b · מתניתין אטעיתיה — the Mishnah that misled Rav Huna · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 47:41

כשל עגל, כשל אווז · THE GEMARA'S EYE CHART



6. One eye big, one eye small — but how big is big, and how small is small?

“Big like a calf's eye, small like a goose's eye — the Gemara's official eye units are farm animals. And a wart in the white of the eye is fine — unless it has hair, which is just too repulsive for the mizbeach.”

— Rabbi Elefant

In the daf: Bekhorot 40b · קטנה כשל אווז, גדולה כשל עגל — eyes like a calf and a goose · Hear it in the shiur: Rabbi Moshe Elefant · 53:18